India would be ‘materially affected by an adverse change in political control of the [Persian/Arabian] Gulf’. Secure British presence in India was also needed to ensure the ‘safety of the great sea route, commercial and military, to India and the Further East’.[37] For Curzon and his successors, the entire sea route from Britain to India had to be construed as Britain’s sphere of influence. During times of British hostility with Russia, any country or power in the Persian Gulf allowing Russia the use of its port was to be regarded by Britain ‘as a deliberate insult, as a wanton rupture of the status quo and as an international provocation to war’.[38]

Indian strategist and historian, K.M. Panikkar argued that it was only after the incorporation of India that the British could exercise influence over Asia because they now had ‘a vast storehouse of power and resources and with a great army and an efficient administrative machinery’.[39] Policies adopted towards Persia, Afghanistan, Tibet, China, Burma and the Arab Middle East were influenced by security considerations based on the geopolitical advantages of a base in India.

Advocates of empire in Britain recognized India’s importance to their global project. For example, Sir Winston Spencer Churchill’s obsession with India reflected the realization that without India, the British Empire would not survive and Britain would no longer be a global player. Churchill may have combined his realism with a professed humanitarian impulse. His father, Lord Randolph Henry Spencer Churchill, served as Secretary of State for India (1885–86), during which time he asserted, ‘Our rule in India is, as it were, a sheet of oil spread out over, and keeping free from storms, a vast and profound ocean of humanity.’

As early as 1931, the younger Churchill wrote that the ‘finest achievement of our history’ was the ‘rescue of India from ages of barbarism, tyranny and internecine war, and its slow but ceaseless forward march to civilization’.[40] For Churchill, a withdrawal of British rule would either lead to ‘Hindu despotism’ or ‘renewal of those ferocious internal